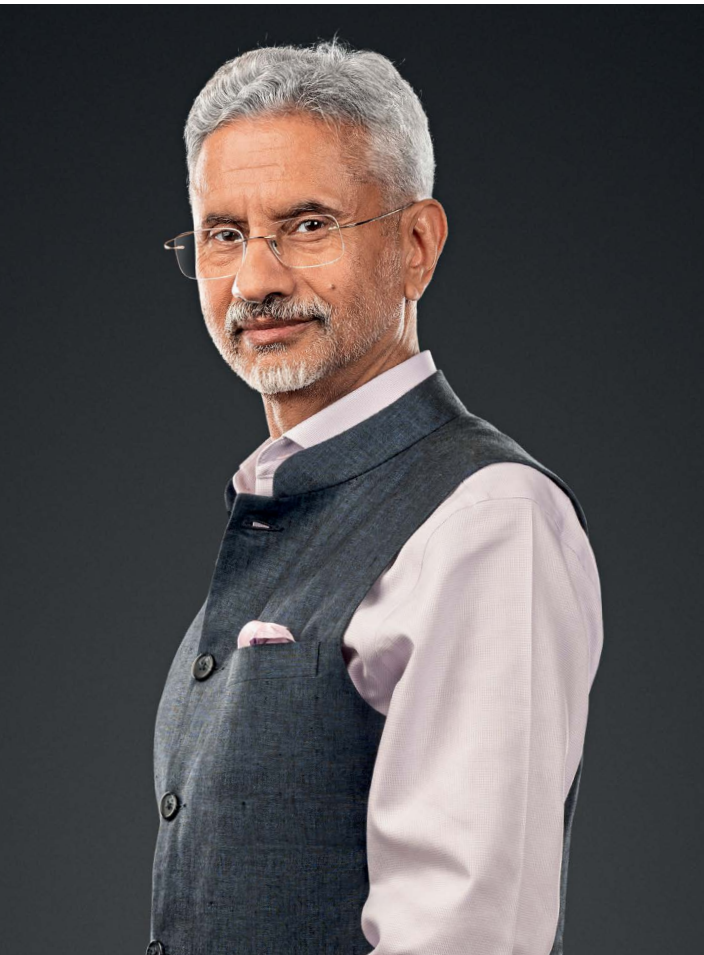




along with people. We believe in things, we share things, we agree on some things. But there are times when you're located in different places, have different levels of development, different experiences – all of that gets into it. So, life is complicated. Life is differentiated. And I think it's very important today not to reduce the entire complexity of our world into very sweeping propositions. I think that era is today behind us."

BUILDING ALLYSHIP

Since 2019, Jaishankar has concentrated on building relationships with several unrelated powers — Europe, the UK, Australia, Indonesia and the Gulf Arab states. Building resilient partnerships is seen as important as building resilient supply chains. That needed a kind of global vision and a sense of India's manifest destiny. In many ways Jaishankar sees India's rise as not merely inevitable, but also transformative. As India assumes a larger

role on the world stage, it is expected to lead by example in areas such as sustainable development, peacekeeping, and ethical governance.

He believes India should now navigate difficult streams and seek opportunities among seeming chaos. The multipolar world, he has said, is upon us, and it provides India a unique opening to create a space for itself at the global high table.

Rather than seeking unilateral dominance, he emphasises that India's growth contributes to a more balanced global power structure. By engaging constructively with nations across the spectrum, India aims to address global challenges—from climate change to security threats—through collective action.

WIELDING CULTURAL SOFT POWER

Jaishankar stresses that India's rise is founded on democratic values, economic resilience, and cultural richness. He believes that this approach serves as a model for how emerging powers can develop without resorting to conflict. The two books Jaishankar wrote as foreign minister focus on explaining the modern world through the cultural lens of Indian epics, the Ramayana and the Mahabharata. It's a key tenet of the Modi government and Jaishankar has been its most articulate spokesman. In many ways, Jaishankar explains Modi to the world. That's no small feat.

Tarun Das, former director general of the Confederation of Indian Industry and someone who has worked with Jaishankar for decades, says, "The external affairs minister is strategic, clear and direct in his diplomacy for India. Today, he commands respect for being the finest foreign minister in the world earning global admiration for India's engagement."

Endowed with a distinct sense of humour and irony, Jaishankar has used it to be devastating, whether to tell off journalists on buying Russian oil ("Europe buys in an afternoon what we buy in a month") or push back against his political opposition in Parliament. In an era of growing political polarisation, Jaishankar can reach across the aisle. Among his ministerial colleagues the joke goes like this: "Jaishankar ji has no interest in anyone else's portfolio. No one else wants his." It's a tribute to his domain expertise, but equally a tribute to the fact that Jaishankar may have transcended what others see as political ambition.

He said some time ago: "Being foreign secretary was the limit of my ambition, I never dreamt of becoming foreign minister. I'm not sure any PM, other than Mr Modi would have made me minister." **BT**

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